

LINE OF OFFICIAL LIST CONTROL

That political power has nothing to do with protocol was established the day Sonia Gandhi heard her inner voice and handed the prime ministerial position to Manmohan Singh. But last year, that principle acquired axiomatic status, whether it was in the sneaky swagger of Prakash Karat or the sarva samaj Ram Lila rumblings of Mayawati. The days of 800-pound gorillas lumbering into positions that matter and hibernating there while popular aspirations boil over into resentment are over. The future clearly belongs to Machiavelli's strong lions and shrewd foxes. These men and women, hungry for power but yet with the stomach for the long haul, are reshaping politics. It could be a chief minister who transforms his corrupt bucolic image with a job well done at the Centre; another satrap who has a say in both a powerful state and an influential sport; or a chief minister who can work the crowds. These politicians have a vision—even if it is only for themselves. Their conviction is what gives them wings above and beyond the designations on their brass name plates.

1 SONIA GANDHI

62, CONGRESS PRESIDENT (1)

HAND IT TO HER

BECAUSE she does not need designations to run the Government or the party. Because the PMO has been outsourced from South Block to 10 Janpath. Because she can swing the Presidential election of a lightweight and pass it off as a "historical occasion". Because even though Congressmen privately feel

